

POWER OF THE PLANETS

Arabic astrology and astral magic

Astral magic (magic connected to the stars and planets) has an ancient tradition but gained its greatest foothold among the Arabic and Persian scholars of the early Islamic world. Common to

all its roots was the belief that a celestial or astral plane existed in between the

divine and the human planes. This was the realm of the stars and planets, and the 12 houses of the zodiac that represented the movement of the stars through the year. Astral magicians believed that every being on earth was influenced by a particular astral power, so they attempted to read the star patterns for guidance and find ways to use the influence of the stars.

Astrology was practiced at many levels of Arabic society, from the marketplace to the court. Initially it was considered an occult practice, at odds with Islam.

Meanwhile, astronomy developed in early Islam, as scholars tried to determine the direction of Mecca and the right times for prayer, and over time the study of the astral plane came to be seen as a legitimate part of natural science. Fusing astrology with science, al-Kindi's 9th-century text, *Kitab al-Shu'at* ("Book of the Rays"), suggested that the stars' influence came through the rays they emitted.

The Picatrix

The translation of Arabic texts into Latin from the 12th century onward had a huge influence on European ideas of magic and science. The most famous book on astral magic was the *Ghāyat al-Hakīm*. Probably written in the 10th or 11th century, it was translated into Latin in the 13th century and went by the name of the *Picatrix*. The *Picatrix* explained the natural links between the planets and intangibles such as colors and

◀ Astrolabe for measuring the stars

Developed by Islamic astrologers and astronomers, astrolabes were used for timekeeping; for surveying and determining the distance and height of objects; for measuring latitude; and for reading horoscopes. This one, made for Sultan Abu-l-Fatih Musa, dates from about 1240.

